

Prompting with examples

One of the easiest ways to improve output is to provide examples. If you want a certain style, show the style. If you want a table, show the columns. If you want a type of answer, show one good answer.

Example:

“Use this format for every recommendation: Product type, who it is for, why it matters, what to check before buying, common mistake.”

Examples reduce ambiguity. They also help the agent match your expectations without endless back-and-forth.

For recurring work, save your best examples in a prompt library. A journalist can save interview question formats. A teacher can save worksheet structures. A founder can save customer reply templates. A student can save revision plan formats.

Approval points: Secret to safe agents

Approval points are what separate safe agents from reckless agents. Every prompt for a task with consequences should include them.

Use lines like:

“Do not send the email. Draft only.”

“Do not make a purchase. Compare options only.”

“Do not delete or overwrite files.”

“Ask before using any personal information.”

“Show me the plan before execution.”

“Stop if the task requires payment, login, legal advice or medical judgement.”

This may feel repetitive, but it is necessary. Agents are useful because they act. They are risky for the same reason.

The final review pass

Before accepting any agent output, run a review prompt.

Use this:

“Review your previous answer. Identify assumptions, possible errors, missing information, unsupported claims and actions that need human approval. Then provide a corrected final version.”

For research: ask for weak sources and outdated information.

For writing: ask for repetition, jargon and unclear sections.

For spreadsheets: ask for calculation errors and missing values.

For coding: ask for security issues and test cases.

For business workflows: ask for privacy, compliance and customer impact risks.

A good agent workflow is not one prompt. It is prompt, output, review, correction and final approval.

Ready-to-use master template

Use this template whenever you are unsure how to brief an agent:

AGENT PROMPTING CHECKLIST

Before pressing enter, check these questions:

1. Is the goal clear?
 2. Have I given enough context?
 3. Have I named the audience?
 4. Have I defined the output format?
 5. Have I stated what the agent must not do?
 6. Have I included approval points?
 7. Have I asked it to show assumptions or uncertainty?
 8. Have I protected sensitive information?
 9. Have I kept the task specific enough to complete?
- If the answer to any of these is no, improve the prompt before running the agent.

“Act as [role]. I need you to [goal]. The context is [background]. Use [files/tools/sources]. Follow these limits: [constraints]. Do not [restricted actions]. First [initial step]. Ask for approval before [sensitive action]. Provide the final output as [format]. Before finalising, check for [errors/assumptions/missing details].”

Example:

“Act as a study coach. I need you to create a 30-day revision plan for Class 12 physics. The context is that I have board exams in six weeks and struggle with numericals. Use the syllabus I upload. Follow these limits: two hours per day on weekdays and four hours on Sundays. Do not skip revision tests. First identify weak chapters. Ask for approval before creating the final timetable. Provide the final output as a weekly table. Before finalising, check if the workload is realistic.”

From Prompting to Workflow Design

The real power of agent-ready prompting is repeatability. You should not write a fresh prompt from zero every time. Once a prompt works, save it. Improve it. Turn it into a workflow.

A student may create a “chapter revision prompt.”

A freelancer may create a “client brief analysis prompt.”

A journalist may create an “interview prep prompt.”

A teacher may create a “worksheet generator prompt.”

A shop owner may create a “customer complaint response prompt.”

A developer may create a “debugging prompt.”

This is where AI agents become genuinely useful. Not because they replace your judgement, but because they turn messy recurring tasks into structured, reviewable systems.

Good prompting is not about tricking AI. It is about managing work clearly. The more responsibility you give an agent, the more precise your brief must be. A vague prompt creates a vague assistant. A clear prompt creates a useful partner. **d**